

BETWEEN WORLDS
The IF Anthology of New Indian SFF, Vol. 1
Edited by Gautam Bhatia
WESTLAND/IF
₹**599; 272** pages

BOOKS ▼

Brave New World

Edited by **Gautam Bhatia**, Between Worlds Vol. 1 *gathers young, first-time authors in a bold anthology that reimagines Indian speculative fiction*

these stories have strong hooks.

Ajay Patri's 'The Last Projectionist' is a banger opener. It is an oral history of one Jayalakshmi, who can mentally project moving images in early 20th century British India. I chuckled at the writer's irreverence: there's a 1930s Englishman called Captain Russell (remember *Lagaan*?), a film critic Shubhra Joshi, surely a portmanteau of real-life critics Shubhra Gupta and Namrata Joshi, and deliberately tacky British dialogue including "blimey" and "shite".

Frank Herbert and Ursula K. Le Guin's stamps are all over Prashanth Srivatsa's 'Muniyamma', as is Margaret Atwood's in Priyamvada Shivaji's 'Sudden Showers'. The former follows a robot with memories of an Indian midwife who helps birth rebel leaders on the planet Peranda. The latter is a coming-of-age tale in a post-apocalyptic scenario where the sea disappears. These stories, and some such as 'Dilli', 'Circa 50 N.E'., begin with promise and potential.

Unsurprisingly, the collection has a melancholic, wistful mood, even when the settings differ—post-apocalyptic rain, lunar gardens, Delhi under corporate rule. What's missing are sharper tonal contrasts: satire, playfulness, grotesque excess, or even outright horror.

Sometimes, there's tactile vividness in the prose ('A Rough-edged Confection', 'We Are All Mayflies'), but the serviceable English in most of them doesn't fully capture the strangeness of the ideas. From *Vol. 2*, I expect more stylistic daring, as seen in the recent *The Blaft Book of Anti-Caste SF*, that fulfills the promise of the speculative premises. ■

—Devarsi Ghosh

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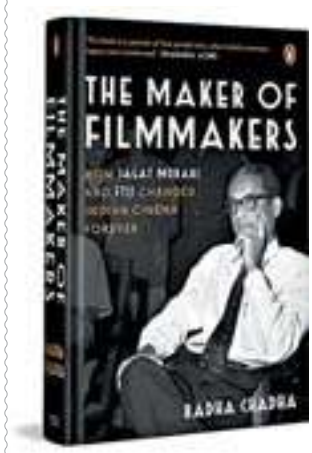
FATHERING FILMS

Radha Chadha's *The Maker of Filmmakers* recounts Jagat Murari's seminal role in Indian cinema

How did a master's degree holder in physics become one of the most pertinent figures of Indian cinema in the immediate aftermath of the country's independence? Radha Chadha's account of Jagat Murari, principal of Film and Television Institute of India (FTII) from 1961 to 1971, a filmmaker with a prolific stint at the government's Films Division, the official entrusted to start the National Film Archive of India—and, coincidentally, Chadha's father—is about the rise and rise and subsequent fall of a man who spent a sizeable chunk of his life battling red tape to lay the foundation of FTII, still considered India's leading filmmaking institute.

Though this is a daughter's account of her father's long—and at times fun, but mostly fraught—journey, the book is surprisingly low on personal details about the man. Instead, Murari comes across as someone consumed with the multiple roles that the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting assigned to him. The book reads like a narration of how FTII came to be and its many achievements during Murari's years, and how the problems it wrestles with to this day—regular strikes, for one—came to be. Where Chadha's book works is as a nostalgia ride for cinephiles yearning for the 'good old days' of Indian cinema and more so as a mirror on how little things have changed when it comes to bureaucratic interference in educational institutions. ■

—Suhani Singh



THE MAKER OF FILMMAKERS
How Jagat Murari and FTII changed Indian cinema forever
By Radha Chadha
PENGUIN
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